UK MEDICINE TRADE: TREND ANALYSIS, 2022–2026 · DATA TO JULY 2026

UK medicine exports are worth less than in 2022, and imports now outweigh them

Before the Budget, the minister needs a clear picture of medicines trade. Exports have lost value every year since 2022. Since a near balance in 2023, the UK has bought more than it sold, by a wider margin each year.

£1,703m	£1,976m	-£273m
Exports a month	Imports a month	Trade gap a month

Average over the 12 months to Jul 2026

By year, £m a month (yearly average). Gap = exports minus imports, worked out before rounding.

	2022	2023	2024	2025	12 months to Jul 2026
Exports	1,884	1,844	1,807	1,749	1,703
Imports	2,223	1,834	1,956	1,995	1,976
Gap	**-339**	**+10**	**-148**	**-246**	**-273**

The 2022 and 2023 figures include eight months of unusually large imports from Israel (£1.02bn).
Without them the 2022 gap is -£261m, and 2023 is still a near balance. Customs data shows what moved, not why. Import countries are countries of dispatch. Amounts are not adjusted for inflation.

Recommendations

01 Packaged medicines — look here first. Over 2022 to 2026 they were 69.5% of export value. Their exports fell each year, from £16.8bn in 2022 to £13.9bn in 2025, and the group went from a £0.7bn surplus in 2024 to a £1.6bn deficit in 2025.
Next step: split them by product and by buyer.

02 Value per kg — find out why before acting. A fall in export value does not always mean a fall in the weight sold. In the latest 12 months, export value fell 7.9% while the weight sold rose 1.8%, so value per kg fell 9.5%. How far value and weight move apart is likely to differ from product to product.
Next step: compare each product's export value against its weight sold, to identify which products have the highest and lowest value per kg.

03 Main buyers and suppliers — keep them in view. Over 2022 to 2026, the top three buyers (the US, Belgium and Germany) took 47% of exports. The US share of exports went from 22.7% in 2022 to 29.2% in 2023 and 23.3% in 2024. Over 2022 to 2026, the top four suppliers (Belgium, the US, the Netherlands and Germany) each sent 12–14% of imports.
Next step: track each country's share every quarter.

What success looks like: the department can say which products and buyers explain the fall in export value, and why value per kg fell.

Data that would help: prices by product, to tell price from product mix, and where imported medicines are made.

The analysis informs the briefing; it does not decide the spending. It is a trend analysis, so it is for the minister to decide what to do with it.